India's LRSAM (long-range surface-to-air missile) system as they tried to keep their distance, yet at times still entered Indian range. Underscoring the centrality of air power in modern warfare, the IAF chief said it can respond swiftly, strike with precision, and achieve objectives without causing collateral damage.

THE PERSONAL FRONT

For Singh, these were not just tactical victories; they were personal milestones. "We've grown up in the air force dreaming about days like this.... I got my chance just before I retired," he said, recalling the strike on the Sargodha airfield as a direct response to hard intelligence on F-16 missions planned against Srinagar and Adampur. The plan was not to wipe out a single base, he explained, but to send an unambiguous message: that India could strike anywhere, at will, and at a time of its choosing.

While detailing the IAF's "kills", Singh stayed silent on aircraft losses on the Indian side. Earlier, Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) General Anil Chauhan had acknowledged that India suffered air losses in the initial phase of the conflict, but dismissed Pakistan's claim of downing six Indian jets as "absolutely incorrect". The DGAO too had conceded that losses are part of any combat, while confirming that all IAF pilots had returned home.

A SUCCESS UNDERPLAYED?

Within India's military community, opinion is split. Some believe the disclosure should have been made immediately after the operation to dominate the narrative. "The entire world should have known of our capabilities then and there," one senior defence official told INDIA TODAY, arguing that the delay ended up ceding the information battlefield to Pakistan.

Former army chief Gen. V.P. Malik went further, calling the success "underplayed". Another officer, wishing to remain anonymous, speculated that Washington D.C.'s sensitivities over the loss of American-made F-16s might have influenced the caution.

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Still, Singh stressed that during Operation Sindoor, the IAF faced no restrictions in planning and execution. "Forces decided what will be our rules of engagement...what will be the escalation ladder that we want to ride on," he said. Days earlier, army chief Gen. Upendra Dwivedi echoed that sentiment at IIT Madras, calling it a "whole of nation" approach with unprecedented political clarity. To the troops, he said, such a "free hand" is a morale-booster. Without naming China, Gen. Dwivedi hinted that "other countries" had helped Pakistan make certain things "visible" during the operation—a veiled reference to Beijing's satellite intelligence support to Islamabad. The campaign, he warned, could easily have stretched from days to months.

Some critics, meanwhile, saw the "freedom of action" framing as a political shield for a government facing Opposition fire in Parliament for its handling of the four-day war.

SENDING SIGNALS ABROAD

Beyond domestic politics, there's an international dimension. Pakistan's arsenal is a mix of American and Chinese platforms. By implying successful strikes on both, India sends a quiet signal to multiple audiences: your equipment can be beaten. It's a double-edged warning aimed at two of Pakistan's closest defence partners. It comes against the backdrop of US–India tensions, as President Donald Trump has slapped India with steep tariffs, citing its ongoing purchases of Russian oil and defence equipment, even as he appears to be reviving ties with Pakistan through overtures to its army chief, Asim Munir.

Some observers believe the IAF chief's disclosure is meant to puncture Pakistan's misinformation campaign—a cognitive warfare playbook likely readied ahead of the Independence Day. Recently, the IAF also released a video montage of the first strikes on Pakistani terror camps after the Pahalgam terror attack, a not-so-subtle reminder of the reach and impact of Indian air power.

So, was this three-month silence a strategic masterstroke or a missed opportunity? On the one hand, the IAF chief's revelations blunt Pakistan's planned propaganda cycle and ties the announcement to a moment when the political debate at home was heating up. On the other, the absence of an immediate claim arguably weakened the psychological impact and allowed the other side to muddy the waters. In warfare, timing is often as critical as firepower. Operation Sindoor's battlefield victories were swift; its public victory is still being contested. ■